



Administrative Directive of the State Court Administrator, 2026-01

Policies on Court Interpreter and Translator Compensation

Authority, applicability, and effective date. Pursuant to Iowa Court Rule 47.12(2), the state court administrator hereby establishes the following statewide policies for the compensation of court interpreters and translators. This administrative directive applies to oral and sign language interpreters and translators of court-related materials who will be paid by a government entity for services provided to limited English proficient (LEP) persons who are participants in judicial branch legal proceedings and predisposition court-ordered programs as defined in Iowa Court Rule 47.1. This administrative directive replaces directive 2024-01 and applies to interpreter and translator services provided on December 1, 2025, and thereafter.

A. Standard hourly fees for court interpreters.

A court interpreter shall receive the following hourly fee based on the classification of court interpreters established in Iowa Court Rules:

1. Oral language interpreters: Classifications defined in Iowa Court Rule 47.4:
 - a. Class A (certified): \$70
 - b. Class B (noncertified): \$60
 - c. Class C (noncertified / on Iowa's roster of court interpreters or on another state's list of approved court interpreters): \$50
 - d. Unclassified (noncertified / not on any state's approved list of court interpreters, but meets minimum qualifications in Iowa Court Rule 47.2): \$30
2. Sign language interpreters: Classifications defined in Iowa Court Rule 47.5:
 - a. Class A (certified – specialist certificate: legal): \$90
 - b. Class B (noncertified): \$60
3. Telephone or remote video interpreters: The standard fees for interpretation provided by primary telephone agencies (e.g., CTS Language Link or Language Line, Inc.) will be established in an agreement with the state court administrator. Telephone or remote video fees for credentialed court interpreters (classifications defined in Iowa Court Rule 47.4) will be paid the same hourly fee as defined in sections A.1 and A.2 above.

B. Exceptions to the standard hourly fees for court interpreters.

1. An interpreter will not be granted a fee that exceeds the hourly fee in section A unless the judicial branch determines a higher fee is necessary under the circumstances to obtain the services of an interpreter who is appropriately qualified pursuant to Iowa Court Rule 47.3(4)-(6), but the higher hourly fee may not exceed the following limits:

- a. \$70 per hour for a noncertified oral language interpreter.
 - b. \$80 per hour for a Class A certified oral language interpreter.
 - c. \$95 per hour for a Class A certified sign language interpreter.
2. An exception to the fee limits established in section B.1 may be granted only by the state court administrator or the state court administrator's designee (hereafter, SCA) before a court assigns an interpreter. SCA will grant an exception only in extraordinary circumstances, which include:
- a. The language of the person who needs an interpreter is uncommon in Iowa and a regional or national search is necessary to obtain the services of a qualified interpreter;
 - b. A diligent search for a qualified interpreter has found the interpreter to be the most qualified and geographically closest interpreter available; and
 - c. Paying a fee that exceeds the fee in section B.1 would cost less than employing the next geographically closest and comparably qualified interpreter.

If SCA approves an exceptional fee, the approval must be in writing and delivered to the district court administrator or the district court administrator's designee (hereafter, DCA) by email.

C. Fees for translators of court-related materials.

1. Standard fee for written translation of documents:
 - a. Upon approval by the court of an application for a written translation of a court-related document pursuant to Iowa Court Rule 47.13(6), the court will direct DCA personnel to locate a translator who meets the qualifications in Iowa Court Rule 47.13(3). A qualified translator may be paid a fee of up to \$.18 per word in the source document.
 - b. When searching for a qualified translator consistent with Iowa Court Rule 47.13(3), court personnel will give preference to certified translators/interpreters who are on Iowa's Roster of Court Interpreters, but will conduct a regional or national search, if necessary, to locate a qualified translator who will provide services for the standard fee in this directive.
2. Exceptions to the standard fee for translation of documents:
 - a. If an application for a written translation of a court-related document has been filed and court personnel are unable to locate a qualified translator who will provide a written translation of a court-related document for the standard fee allowed by section C.1, the DCA will submit a request for assistance via email to the SCA's office. The request will include a copy of the document to be translated, a copy of the Application for Approval of a Written Translation and Appointment of a Translator, and the date the translation should be delivered to the court.
 - b. SCA will locate a qualified translator and provide the court with the name of a qualified translator and the fee to be paid to the translator. The court will

include that information in the Order Approving a Written Translation of Court-related Material and Appointing a Translator.

3. Standard fee for written translation of an audio or audio-video recording of communications involving at least one LEP person:
 - a. Upon approval by the court of an application for a written translation or transcription of an audio or video recording of communications, pursuant to Iowa Court Rule 47.13(6), the court will direct DCA personnel to locate a translator who meets the qualifications in Iowa Court Rule 47.13(3). A qualified translator for a written translation of audio or video recording may be paid their standard interpreter hourly rate (as agreed with SCA) per minute of audio or video recording. One minute of audio/video recording shall equal one hour of billable time.
 - b. When searching for a qualified translator consistent with Iowa Court Rule 47.13(3), court personnel will give preference to certified translators/interpreters who are on Iowa's Roster of Court Interpreters, but will conduct a regional or national search, if necessary, to locate a qualified translator who will provide services for the standard fee in this directive.
4. Exceptions to the standard fee for translation of audio-video recordings: If an application for a written translation of a court-related audio or video recording has been filed and court personnel are unable to locate a qualified translator who will provide a written translation of a court-related document for the standard fee allowed by section C.3, the DCA will submit a request for assistance via email to the SCA's office. The request will include a copy of the audio or video recording to be translated, a copy of the Application for Approval of Audio or Video Translation and Appointment of a Translator, and the date the translation should be delivered to the court.
5. Minimum translation fee: For a written translation related to a single case or party, a translator will receive a fee of not less than \$40 if the court approves the written translation pursuant to Iowa Court Rule 47.13.

D. Compensation of interpreter services agencies. An interpreter services agency will be paid the standard fee for the interpreter's classification in [section A](#). An exception may be granted for good cause by SCA in writing prior to the proceeding.

E. Definition of contractual terms. The following definitions will apply in the absence of a written agreement or court order that specifically identifies or defines other terms or conditions for the provision of court interpreting services:

1. "Contracted time" is the amount of time that a court interpreter agrees to provide interpreting services. It includes the start and estimated finish time for the court proceeding identified by a court employee or a representative of the entity that will pay the interpreter.

2. A “trial day” or a “full day” will be seven hours. It begins at 8:30 AM, ends at 4:30 PM, and excludes one hour for lunch; other breaks will be paid time. If the lunch period exceeds one hour, the interpreter will be paid for the extra lunch time as “waiting time.” If the court proceeding begins before 8:30 AM or extends beyond 4:30 PM, or an LEP party or that party’s attorney requests interpreter services before a court proceeding begins, after it ends, or during the lunch break, the interpreter will be paid for the additional work time.
3. A “half day” will be 3.5 hours (including break time) morning session 8:30 AM to 12:00 PM, afternoon session 1:00 PM to 4:30 PM, unless either session begins earlier or ends later.

F. Minimum interpreting time.

1. When a court assigns an interpreter to provide services for court proceedings, the interpreter will be paid a minimum of two hours for each morning and two hours for each afternoon, not a minimum of two hours for each interpreted proceeding in a morning or afternoon (unless scheduled for a full or half day per sections E.2 and E.3). For the purpose of minimum pay, a two-hour payment period commences at the time the interpreting service is scheduled to begin. If the assignment runs over the two-hour minimum, the interpreter is expected to remain with the case until released by the court.
2. If an interpreter provides services for more than one case during the morning or afternoon, the interpreter will divide the time among the cases when submitting claims for compensation.
3. No two-hour minimum payment period shall overlap with another two-hour minimum payment period.
4. An exception to the two-hour minimum fee must be approved by SCA in writing and delivered to the DCA prior to the interpreted event.
5. When a court assigns an interpreter to provide services in a case, and the interpreter agrees to assist an attorney during communications with an LEP party at a location outside of court in preparation for a court proceeding, the interpreter will be paid a minimum of two hours for each morning of interpreting for the same attorney and two hours for each afternoon of interpreting for the same attorney, whether the interpreter provides those services remotely or in-person.

G. Waiting and preparation time.

1. If a court schedules an interpreter to provide services at a court proceeding and the interpreter appears at the court facility at the scheduled time, the waiting time between the scheduled and the actual starting times is reimbursable. When submitting a fee claim, an interpreter will divide the waiting time among all the clients or cases for

which the interpreter provides services during a given assignment. Time between different scheduled assignments does not constitute waiting time and is not payable.

2. When more than one interpreter has provided services during a jury trial, only one interpreter at a time will be paid for time beyond the contracted time to wait for and interpret the jury's verdict. If the interpreters do not agree which interpreter will wait for the jury's verdict, the court will select one. While waiting for the verdict to be returned, the interpreter must remain within a 15-minute drive of the trial location.
3. An interpreter will not be compensated for time spent reviewing case-related documents in preparation for a court or legal proceeding unless:
 - a. The court or SCA approves such review; or
 - b. The interpreter is to serve as an expert witness regarding the accuracy of a recorded interpretation, or a written translation of court-related material produced by another interpreter or translator.

H. Reimbursable travel time.

1. A court interpreter will only be reimbursed for travel time when they must travel to a county outside the interpreter's county of residence to provide services with possible exceptions for jail assignments. Round-trip travel time between a court interpreter's residence and the court or other location where the interpreter provides services will be paid at the same hourly rate as for their interpreting services or \$70 per hour, whichever is less.
2. Calculation of travel time will be as follows: The total round-trip travel miles, as determined by Google Maps, between the interpreter's residence and the courthouse or location where the interpreted activity occurs, divided by 55 (miles per hour). Additional travel time may be granted only if the interpreter encountered weather-related road conditions (e.g., ice or snow) of such severity that it necessarily extended the travel time and noted on the fee claim as such.
3. If a proceeding will be conducted on more than one day and an interpreter's residence is outside the county where the proceeding is located, the judicial branch will determine whether it is less expensive to pay the interpreter for round-trip travel time or for overnight lodging and meals at state rates (see [Attachment 1](#) below) for the evenings before and between the days of the proceeding. The interpreter will be reimbursed an amount equal to the less expensive option regardless of which option the interpreter chooses.

Note: Iowa law* specifies that a public employer (which includes the judicial branch) and public employee shall not use public funds to procure lodging from a lodging provider that is not certified as having completed human trafficking prevention training. Contracted interpreters are not public employees, and the judicial branch does not use public funds to procure lodging for interpreters, but the judicial branch strongly encourages independent contract interpreters who need overnight lodging to

procure any necessary lodging services from providers that are certified as having completed **human trafficking prevention training**. Certified providers are identified at the following website: <https://stopthiowa.org/certified-locations>.

**See Iowa Code subsection 80.45A(5)(C)*

4. Interpreters assigned to multi-day court events (e.g., trials) who would prefer to commute home in between multi-day court events, may request to do so only if one-way travel is under three hours and with prior approval from the coordinator. Once the event begins, commuting decisions cannot be changed unless approved for emergencies. The coordinator may revoke commuting approval due to safety concerns like weather. Interpreters who choose to commute forfeit lodging, meals, and daily travel time compensation, and may only invoice for state-rate lodging on travel days. They must note “commuting elected” on their fee claim.
5. When submitting a fee claim, an interpreter will divide reimbursable travel time among all the cases for which the interpreter provided services at the location to which the interpreter travelled.
6. When there is no difference in the classifications of interpreters under Court Rule 47.3(4)-(5), an interpreter who resides within the same county should be assigned before an interpreter who resides outside the county.

I. Travel expenses: mileage, lodging, meals, and airline or other public transportation.

1. When payment of travel expenses (in addition to travel time) is necessary to obtain the services of a qualified interpreter for a court proceeding, the DCA or the DCA’s designee will negotiate with the interpreter or interpreter services agency to limit these expenses consistent with the compensation terms in this administrative directive.
2. Reimbursement of travel expenses will be up to state-approved rates in [Attachment 1](#) below unless SCA approves an exception.
3. When the closest qualified interpreter resides in a location where airline transportation is the least expensive travel option, but the interpreter expresses a preference for driving, the DCA will estimate the costs of travel by airline (including travel to and from the airports at both locations, parking fees, and payment for travel time) and by automobile (including payment for travel time) and will offer to reimburse the interpreter an amount equal to the less expensive option, regardless of which travel option the interpreter chooses.
4. Reimbursement for travel expenses must be approved by SCA or DCA before an interpreter incurs such expenses.

5. Meal expenses will be reimbursed at state rates (see [Attachment 1](#) below) only when overnight lodging has been approved for the interpreter prior to the proceeding. Hotel receipts are required to be submitted with fee claim, but meal receipts are not required.
6. Reimbursement for travel mileage may be approved in writing by SCA only in extraordinary circumstances identified in [section B.2](#). If approved by SCA, the per mile reimbursement rate for contractors is the same as the standard mileage rate for in-state travel reimbursement for state employees. The rate can be found at <https://das.iowa.gov/state-accounting/manuals-forms-references/reference-materials>.
7. If a proceeding unexpectedly extends to an additional day and the interpreter resides more than one hundred miles from the location of the proceeding, an interpreter may be reimbursed for lodging plus dinner and breakfast at state rates without prior written approval by the court.

Note: The judicial branch strongly encourages independent contract interpreters who need overnight lodging to procure any necessary lodging services from providers that are certified as having completed **human trafficking prevention training**. Please see *Note* in [section H.3](#).

8. At the end of an interpreted proceeding, if an interpreter would normally travel back to the interpreter's residence but severe weather makes such travel hazardous (e.g., due to ice or heavy snow), an interpreter may be reimbursed for lodging and meals without prior written approval by the judicial branch and must not inclement weather on fee claim.

J. Avoidable travel expenses. Any travel expenses incurred by an interpreter after receiving notice of a cancellation of a court proceeding at which the interpreter was supposed to provide services will not be reimbursed.

K. Unavoidable travel expenses.

1. If an interpreter purchases nonrefundable transportation tickets (airline, train or bus) or hotel accommodations after receiving approval in advance from the DCA and the proceeding for which the interpreter was needed is cancelled and the interpreter is notified of the cancellation at within 24 hours before the scheduled departure time, the interpreter will be reimbursed for the cost incurred by the interpreter for cancelling the tickets (e.g., the ticket change fee charged by most airlines). Reimbursement for notifications outside of the 24-hour cancellation period will be looked at on a case-by-case basis.
2. If notice of a cancellation is delivered to an interpreter after the interpreter has travelled at least part of the distance to the location where services are to be provided, and that location is outside the interpreter's county of residence, actual travel time (not

expected travel time) and other previously approved travel expenses actually incurred are reimbursable.

- L. Parking costs.** If a proceeding is conducted in a location where an interpreter must pay for parking, actual parking costs are reimbursable up to \$8 per day without a receipt, and up to \$15 per day with a receipt. Receipt must be submitted with fee claim.

M. Notice of cancellation of agreement.

1. A court interpreter receives notice of a cancellation when a court employee, attorney representing the person who needs the interpreter, or employee of the office that will pay the interpreter, delivers notice of a cancellation to the interpreter by email to the email address provided by the court interpreter, or by voice, text or fax message at a phone number provided by the court interpreter, or through verbal communication with a representative of the court interpreter at a phone number provided by the court interpreter, not when the court interpreter actually hears or reads the message.
2. Iowa Court Rule 47.3(13) establishes an interpreter's obligations when an interpreter is unable to provide interpreting services for a court proceeding for which the interpreter previously agreed to provide services.

N. Payment of a court interpreter upon cancellation of agreement.

1. If a court interpreter is given notice of a cancellation of a court proceeding, at least 24 hours prior to the scheduled start time (excluding weekends, holidays, non-regular judicial business hours), the court interpreter will not receive compensation for the cancelled interpreting time or cancelled travel time unless previously approved otherwise.
2. For one full day (or less) assignments: If a court interpreter is given notice of a cancellation of a court proceeding, less than 24 hours prior to the scheduled start time (excluding weekends, holidays, non-regular judicial business hours), **OR** if the court interpreter receives notice (due to settlement or guilty plea, etc.) after beginning to provide interpreting services for the proceeding, the court interpreter will receive either the full hourly rate for the contracted time or for seven hours, whichever is less, plus any actual reimbursable travel time incurred and any previously approved nonrefundable travel expenses incurred prior to receiving notice of the cancellation. An interpreter will not receive compensation for any travel time not incurred prior to the notice of the cancellation.
3. For multi-day assignments (trials): If a court interpreter is given notice of a cancellation of a court proceeding, less than 24 hours prior to the scheduled start time (excluding weekends, holidays, non-regular judicial business hours) **AND** the interpreter does NOT appear for court (in-person or remote), the court interpreter will receive reimbursement as follows:

- two-day assignment = 7 hours
- three-day (or more) assignment = 14 hours

Plus, any actual reimbursable travel time incurred and any previously approved non-refundable travel expenses incurred prior to receiving notice of the cancellation. An interpreter will not receive compensation for any travel time not incurred prior to the notice of the cancellation.

4. For multi-day assignments (e.g. trials): If a court interpreter is given notices of a cancellation of a court proceeding less than 24 hours prior to the scheduled start time (excluding weekends, holidays, non-regular judicial business hours) **AND the interpreter DOES appear for court (in-person or remote)**, the court interpreter will receive reimbursement as follows:

- two-day assignment = 14 hours
- three-day (or more) assignment = 21 hours

Plus any actual reimbursable travel time incurred and any previously approved non-refundable travel expenses incurred prior to receiving notice of the cancellation. An interpreter will not receive compensation for any travel time not incurred prior to the notice of the cancellation.

5. If after receiving notice of a cancellation, a court interpreter is able to obtain alternate employment as an interpreter to substitute for part or all the cancelled court interpreting time, the court interpreter will subtract the amount of fees earned through the alternate interpreting work from the amount owed to the interpreter for the cancelled court interpreting time.
6. If a court interpreter completes one morning or afternoon two-hour minimum assignment and is also scheduled for another assignment for the same morning or afternoon, but the second assignment gets cancelled (within 24 hours), the cancelled assignment is not eligible for another two-hour minimum pursuant to [sections F.1 and F.3](#). However, waiting time for the second assignment is payable up from the time the assignment was scheduled to start up until the time the interpreter receives the notification of cancellation (same day).

O. Managing the number of court interpreters and interpreter costs. See Iowa Court Rules 47.3(12)(e) and (f).

P. Fee claims for court interpreter or translator services.

1. Except as provided in section P.2, an interpreter or translator is highly encouraged to submit a copy of the interpreter's or translator's fee itemization form and receipts (if applicable) to the clerk of court in the county where the case was located as soon as possible after completing the assignment or translation service, but no later than 30 days after. Submissions to the clerk of courts office or to the county auditor (if applicable) received after 60 days of the completion of services will not be paid pursuant to Iowa Court Rule 47.3(14). Fee claims are timely only if all documents

required for payment are submitted within 60 days from the date of services. Fee claims that do not have supporting documents (receipts) or submitted within 60 days from the date of services will be denied payment. The fee itemization forms and instructions for submitting fee claims can be found in the court interpreters' section of the Iowa courts' website at: <https://www.iowacourts.gov/iowa-courts/court-interpreters/info-for-current-interpreters/>

2. For services provided between June 15 and June 30 each year, an interpreter must submit the fee claim (and receipts if applicable) to the clerk of court by July 30 of that year.
3. SCA, in its sole discretion, may grant an exception when an interpreter provides substantial and convincing evidence that some extraordinary condition(s) beyond the interpreter's control prevented the interpreter from submitting a fee claim within the 60-day time period and caused by one of the circumstances listed in Iowa Court Rule 47.3(14)(b). Fee claims submitted pursuant to an exception from the 60-day period must be submitted with all documents required for payment within 90 days from the date on which the interpreter services were performed, or payment will be denied.
4. When SCA is responsible for paying a court interpreter, SCA personnel who manage interpreter fee claims may reduce, modify, or deny the amount of payment to an interpreter, even if the DCA has approved the interpreter's fee claim, if:
 - a. The claimant incorrectly calculated the fees or expenses;
 - b. This administrative directive or the Iowa Court Rules do not authorize reimbursement of the claimant for the type of expense(s) claimed;
 - c. The claimant failed to obtain prior approval of a claimed expense as required by this directive or by court or administrative rule;
 - d. The amount of time or expenses claimed exceeded the amount approved prior to performance of the interpreting or translating services; or
 - e. The claimant's fee claim was not received within 60 days from date of service.
5. An interpreter may submit a written request for the SCA to review a reduction in compensation by SCA personnel. A written request for review must include an explanation for why the reduction of the interpreter's fee by SCA personnel was not appropriate. The SCA's decision on the matter will be final.

Q. Clerk's responsibility to process interpreter and translator fee claims.

1. Clerks of court or designated staff are expected to check their generic clerk of court email inbox each day to determine whether an interpreter or translator has emailed the clerk a fee itemization form. Once a fee itemization is received the clerk's staff will promptly upload the fee claim into the Interpreter Application.

2. DCA approvers, or their designated staff, are expected to check the Interpreter Application each day, or at minimum every other day, to ensure that interpreter fee claims are being reviewed and approved in a timely manner.
3. Clerk's staff will enter the appropriate FIN code into the case management system to direct reimbursement payments of oral language interpreter or translator fees by the party or parties to the judicial branch's jury, witness, and interpreter fund established pursuant to Iowa Code section 602.1302(3).

The prior administrative directive (2024-01) is hereby rescinded, and this directive is effective on December 1, 2025.

Dated this 9th day of February 2026.



Robert Gast
State Court Administrator

Copies to:
Director of Language Access Services
District Language Access Coordinators
Interpreters on Iowa's Roster of Court Interpreters

Attachment 1

State Rates for Reimbursement of Travel Related Costs for Court Interpreters

Types of travel expenses ¹	State Reimbursement Rates
Hotel / lodging*	\$80 per night plus applicable taxes = \$89.60
Meals ²	\$ 8 – breakfast \$10 – lunch \$19 – dinner
Mileage (Interpreters are paid for their travel time; reimbursement for mileage is rarely approved by SCA) ³	When approved by SCA, the per mile reimbursement rate for contractors is the same as the standard mileage rate or in-state travel reimbursement for state employees. The rate can be found at: Reference Material Iowa Department of Administrative Services

¹ These expenses must be approved in writing before the expenses are incurred by the office required to pay the interpreter. See [section I](#).

² If an overnight stay is approved in advance, breakfast is reimbursed if a claimant leaves home prior to 6:00 AM to arrive at the work location; and dinner is reimbursed if the claimant returns home after 7:00 PM.

³ SCA = State Court Administration

**Note:* The judicial branch strongly encourages independent contract interpreters who need overnight lodging to procure any necessary lodging services from providers that are certified as having completed human trafficking prevention training. See *Note* under [section H.3](#).

**Note:* This attachment will be updated when reimbursement rates change.